

matchday thriller, reminiscent of the 2000-01 season of the National Football League or the 2017-18 I-League.

These were times when East Bengal and Bagan dominated the podiums of Indian football, playing each derby neck-and-neck and dragging title races to the very end. In the 2000-01 campaign, East Bengal won the title by a solitary point over Bagan. In 2017-18, both Kolkata giants stumbled with draws on the final day, allowing Minerva Punjab to clinch the I-League title.

In the 2025-26 season, a win in Sunday's derby would have eliminated the loser from the race.

But the draw ensured people would remain glued to developments on the final matchday, when Bagan takes on Sporting Club Delhi and East Bengal locks horns with Inter Kashi. A 2017-18-esque ending is also possible, wherein both teams draw their respective matches, in which case a winner in Mumbai City vs Punjab FC would be crowned ISL champion.

By the time you read this, the ISL will have a champion, but this season, though truncated, will be remembered as the one that saw the revival of the Maidan rivalry on the biggest stage of Indian men's domestic football.

Meanwhile, the other club of Kolkata's Big Three, Mohammedan Sporting, became the first team to be relegated from the ISL.

The Black Panthers, who had found fresh life under coach Andrey Chernyshov by winning the I-League and Calcutta Football League, were plunged into a severe financial crisis, which ultimately led them to field an all-Indian side. With just three draws in 12 matches, they will begin next season in the Indian Football League (IFL), the second division of men's football.

The fall of one club, however, will mark the rise of another from the same state.

Diamond Harbour FC (right), founded just six years ago, started its journey to the top under the



tutelage of I-League-winning coach Kibu Vicuna.

The Spaniard, who had inspired Bagan to the I-League title in the 2019-20 season, orchestrated a meteoric rise starting from I-League 3 and eventually winning the IFL to earn qualification into the ISL.

The club's journey has several subplots of redemption.

Halicharan Narzary, who had once scored the ISL-winning penalty for Hyderabad FC in 2022, moved to Bengaluru FC a year later, only to struggle for regular first-team opportunities.

Jobby Justin, once a regular for East Bengal in the pre-ISL days, knocked his former side out of the Durand Cup last year and led

Eternal rivals: This ISL season will be remembered for reviving the Maidan rivalry on the biggest stage of Indian men's domestic football. IFL MEDIA/AIFF

Diamond Harbour to the men's top flight this season.

But football is rarely without drama, especially at the business end of tournaments.

Needing a draw to clinch the title against Dempo SC, Marcus Joseph gave the Goan side the lead in the 50th minute. Just when Dempo thought it had won the match, Hugo Diaz turned the tables in second-half stoppage time to force a 1-1 draw and send his team to seventh heaven.

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